

Alabama Learning Hour

What happened at the Powwow? Talking about the past

February 3rd, 2026

1 Naat̓iilka Dialogue

Naasok sahmiḥchō powwow-kafa?

What happened at the powwow?

① Maxine, an elder, asks Tanya about the Powwow.

Maxine: Naksok ittanowwahchō bitkafa?

Tanya: Avak aayati piyaaka.

Maxine: Avak naason sahmiḥchō?

Tanya: Bitlihan hiichati.

Bokoko batliyon īhaaloti

Hono okchakkohchon choopati

① English.

Maxine: Who was at the powwow?

Tanya: Ava was there yesterday.

Maxine: What did Ava do?

Tanya: She saw the dancers.

She listened to the drums beating

She bought a blue shirt.

2 Vocabulary

Nouns

Powwow-Related

aabitka	dancing ground
bokoko	drum
bitka	dance
bitliha	dancers
chassi bitka	corn dance
chokfi bitka	rabbit dance
isbitka holikfa	regalia/clothes for dancing
hono	skirt
Powwow-ka	Powwow

Food & Drink

fołka	sofkey
nipo	meat
oolimpa	food
paspa spoyatli	frybread
tiika (champoli)	(sweet) tea
yakchi	yakchi

Date & Time

himaaka nihta	today
piyaaka	yesterday

Verbs

Ka-Verbs

afaaka	to laugh
isko	to drink

Li-Verbs

bokoko batli
bitli
chiyahli
ilakomayli
sahmi

to beat/hit drums
to dance
to walk
to swim
to happen how? be like what?

Simple-Verbs

aaya
choopa
hiicha
hompani
ittanowwa
inhaalo
okchakko
oompa

to be located/around (for one or two people)
to buy
to see/watch
to play
to be located/around (for multiple people)
to listen to someone/somebody
to be blue
to eat

3 Grammar

3.1 Past Tense *-ti/hchõ*: *What did she do yesterday?*

- Many languages care a lot about whether something is a **statement** or a **question!** Consider English:

(1) Ava danced.

(2) Did Ava dance?

- When we talk about past in Alabama, we add different pieces to the verb depending on whether we are making a statement or asking a question.

Past Tense -*ti/hchõ* Easy Recipe – One noun

(3) Statement

[**Subject** + **k**] [**Verb** + **-ti**].

Ava-k bitli-**ti**.

‘Ava danced’.

Piyaaka Ava-k bitli-**ti**.

‘Yesterday Ava danced’.

(4) Question

[**Subject** + **k**] [**Verb** + **-hchõ**]? **?**

Ava-k bitli-**hchõ**?

‘Did Ava dance?’

Piyaaka Ava-k bitli-**hchõ**?

‘Did Ava dance yesterday’?

- Add *-k* to the ‘Subject’ of the action.
- If you’re making a statement about the past, add *-ti* to the verb.
- If you’re asking a question about the past, add *hchō* to the verb.
- First put the Subject, then the Verb—*and you’re done!*

Past Tense -ti/hchō Recipe with two nouns

(5) **Statement**

[**Subject** + **k**] [**Object** + **n**] [**Verb** + **-ti**].

Ava-k bitliha-n hiicha-**ti**. Piyaaka Ava-k bitliha-n hiicha-**ti**.
'Ava watched the dancers'. 'Yesterday Ava watched the dancers'.

(6) **Question**

[**Subject** + **k**] [**Object** + **n**] [**Verb** + **-hchō**].

Ava-k bitliha-n hiicha-**hchō**? Piyaaka Ava-k bitliha-n hiicha-**hchō**?
'Did Ava watch the dancers?' 'Did Ava dance yesterday'?

- Add *-k* to the 'Subject' of the action.
- Add *-n* to the 'Object' of the action. Who is it happening to? Who is undergoing the action?
- If you're making a statement about the past, add *-ti* to the verb.
- If you're asking a question about the past, add *hchō* to the verb.
- First put the Subject, then the Verb—and you're done!

- 'Yesterday' in Alabama is *piyaaka*.
- 'Yes' in Alabama is *ay* (pronounced as in: hey!).

Let's practice with a partner! *How would you say this in Alabama?*

- (7) Q: Did Ava laugh?
A: Yes, Ava laughed.
- (8) Q: Did Tanya beat the drums yesterday?
A: Yes, Tanya beat the drums yesterday.
- (9) Q: Did your friend (*chimokla*) buy Sofkey?
A: Yes, my friend (*amokla*) bought Sofkey.
- (10) Q: Did Ava swim yesterday?
A: Yes, Ava swam yesterday.
- (11) Q: Did the dog (*ifa*) run (*waliika*)?
A: Yes, the dog ran.
- (12) Q: Did Ava play yesterday?
A: Yes, Ava played yesterday.
- (13) Q: Did the child (*poskoosi*) laugh?
A: Yes, the child laughed.
- (14) Q: Did Ava buy a skirt yesterday?
A: Yes, Ava bought a skirt.
- (15) Q: Did Maxine watch the dancers?
A: Yes, Maxine watched the dancers.
- (16) Q: Did your friend (*chimokla*) play yesterday?
A: Yes, my friend (*amokla*) played yesterday.
- (17) (CHALLENGE)
Q: What happened at the Powwow yesterday?
A: _____ [Make your own response!]

Now, let's use a simple version of our dialogue and practice with our new vocab words!

Dialogue 1 practice

In the following exercise, with a partner, translate the phrases in columns B and C into Alabama and insert them in the blanks in the dialogue example.

Person 1: Naksok ittanowwahchō bitkafa?

Person 2: A: ex. Tanya-**k** aayati piyaaka.

Person 1: A: ex. Tanya-**k** B: ex. chiyahli-**hchō**?

Person 2: Ay, mooton C: ex. bokoko batli -**ti**.

New Vocab: *mooton* - also

A	B	C
ex. Tanya	walk	beat drums
1. Maxineka	did she dance?	laugh
2. Jacobka	did he play?	ate sofkey
3. Ava	did she watch the corn dance?	watched the rabbit dance
4. Your own!	Your own!	Your own!

Vocab for exercise: *bitli* - dance, *afaaka* - laugh, *hompani* - play, *fołka oompa* - eat sofkey, *chassi bitka hiicha* - watch the corn dance, *chokfi bitka hiicha* - watch the rabbit dance

3.2 Talking about one person, versus multiple people: *ittanowwa* and *aaya*

- In Alabama, there are many verbs that in English are one word, but in Alabama, there are two completely different words, depending on if *one* person is doing it, *two* people, or *more than two*!
- We saw one of these examples in the dialogue today: *aaya* vs *ittanowwa* ‘to be located somewhere, to attend an event’
- If you want to talk about one or two people or things, you need to use *aaya* (for two people, you should add -chi to the end of *aaya*) For verbs like ‘aaya’, we’ll call this a ‘Singular stem’. We may also include special verbs that have a form JUST for two people. That will be called the ‘Dual stem’.

Avak aayati powwowkafa	<i>‘Ava was at the Powwow.’</i>
Bitliha aayachiti powwowkafa	<i>‘The (two) dancers were at the Powwow.’</i>

- To talk about multiple people or objects, *ittanowwa* is used. For simplicity, we’ll call this the ‘Plural stem’.

Bitliha ittanowwati	<i>‘Dancers were at the Powwow.’</i>
Mobilak ittanowwamooti	<i>‘There were too many cars around.’</i>

- To ask a question about an unknown number of people, you should default on the side of caution, and use the ‘plural’ stem.

✓Naksok ittanowwahchō powwowkafa?	<i>‘Who all was at the Powwow?’</i>
✗Naksok aayahchō powwowkafa?	<i>‘Who was at the Powwow?’</i>

- One Elder said this: “[*naksok aayahchō?*] may not be a proper question, because when you go to an event, they may be a lot of people there. Unless you’re talking about a particular person, then I would say *Avak aayati powwowkafa*. [But] in general, I would say *ittanowwa*’

3.3 -ka: Using English loanwords in Alabama

- Alabama doesn’t have a native word for every possible concept—especially when it comes to names, you have to change names slightly when talking about them in Alabama.
- When we want to use an English word that doesn’t exist in Alabama, we do one of two things:

1. If the English word ends in a ‘light syllable’ that sounds like ‘uh’ (example: Tanya, Ava, Micah, Sarah) we do nothing!
2. If it ends in an -er sound, like in Peter, Alexander, (even if it’s not spelled that way, like in *wire*), we pronounce it like we were british and replace the -er with a ‘uh’ sound:

Peter →	/piita/
Alexander →	/aleksanda/
brother →	/braḷa/
sister →	/sista/
wire →	/waya/

3. Otherwise, we add -ka to the end of the word!

Powwow → powwow-ka
Jacob → Jacob-ka
Jackson → Jackson-ka
Nicolas → Nicolas-ka

★ Every language uses loanwords! It's completely natural to use English words in Alabama: All the elders do it!

★ English has loanwords too! Did you know that the word Beef is a French word? And Barbecue is a word from the Taíno tribe? Even Texas is a loanword!

★ Sometimes, even when there's an Alabama word, people will still use the English loanword!

☞ Some people will say “frybread-ka” instead of *paspa spoyatli* or “sista” instead of *ifoni* (for men) or *chaachi* (for women).

★ So don't feel bad about using English loanwords in Alabama. If there's no better way to express yourself, sometimes you have to!